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The Future in Mind: Aspirations and Long-Term Outcomes in Rural Ethiopia

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Can a light-touch aspirations intervention change long-run economic outcomes among very poor rural households?
- **Setting.** The experiment is conducted in Doba, a remote rural district in Ethiopia, with 1,152 households and 2,112 individuals in 64 villages.
- **Intervention.** Households randomly invited to treatment watched four short documentaries about people from similar rural backgrounds who escaped poverty through effort, planning, perseverance, and attainable investments.
- **Comparison groups.** A placebo group watched an Ethiopian entertainment program; a within-village control group was surveyed but not invited to a screening.
- **Main finding.** Five years after the videos, treated households invest more in agriculture, children's education, durable assets, and housing, and they report higher aspirations and expectations.
- **Mechanism.** The evidence points toward aspirations and expectations rather than time preferences, risk preferences, grit, information about technologies, or perceived agricultural returns.
- **Economic takeaway.** Aspirations can be a state variable in poverty dynamics: changing what households see as attainable can shift effort and investment, which then produces durable changes in assets and education.

2 Data and measurement

2.1 Context and sample

Doba was poor, mountainous, and remote; many villages were difficult to access, and exposure to television was low at baseline. The authors randomly selected 84 villages from 189 rural villages in Doba and used 64 villages for the experiment, based on distance to 16 feasible screening sites. In each village, 18 households were randomly sampled for baseline survey and treatment assignment. The main sample contains 1,152 households and 2,112 individuals.

Interpretation. The setting is ideal for a role-model video intervention because the medium was memorable and the depicted stories were close enough to local circumstances to be relatable.

2.2 Survey timeline and treatment arms

Baseline and intervention occurred between September and November 2010, a six-month follow-up between March and May 2011, and a five-year follow-up between December 2015 and January 2016. Treated households watched four 15-minute documentaries in Oromiffa. The placebo group watched four segments of an Ethiopian comedy show about rural life. The control group was surveyed but did not attend a screening.

Interpretation. The placebo group separates the aspirations content from the generic effects of being invited to a group screening, seeing outsiders, or watching video media.

2.3 Aspirations, expectations, and outcomes

Aspirations measure what respondents would like to achieve for income, wealth, and children's education. Expectations measure what respondents think they will achieve in 10 years. Outcomes include agricultural investment, education investment, welfare, aspirations, expectations, and mechanism measures.

Interpretation. The paper distinguishes goals from expected outcomes and shows that both move with treatment.

3 Models and empirical specifications

3.1 Main treatment-effect regression

$$Y_{iv} = \alpha + \beta_T \text{Treatment}_{iv} + \beta_P \text{Placebo}_{iv} + \gamma X_{iv0} + \delta_v + \varepsilon_{iv}.$$

Here δ_v are village fixed effects. β_T is the treatment-control effect, β_P is the placebo-control effect, and $\beta_T - \beta_P$ compares aspirations content to placebo screening.

Interpretation. The treatment-versus-placebo contrast is especially informative because both groups received a screening but only one watched aspiration-targeting content.

3.2 ANCOVA and summary indices

$$Y_{iv, \text{followup}} = \alpha + \beta_T T_{iv} + \beta_P P_{iv} + \rho Y_{iv, \text{baseline}} + \gamma X_{iv0} + \delta_v + \varepsilon_{iv}.$$

The paper constructs Anderson (2008) inverse-covariance weighted indices and reports q-values for multiple hypothesis testing.

Interpretation. Indices are important because the intervention affects several related behaviors with moderate individual effects.

4 Identification and empirical design

- Assignment occurs within villages, so village fixed effects absorb village-level differences.
- The placebo group controls for generic media and screening effects.
- Results are mostly robust to alternative specifications, baseline controls, and post-double-selection LASSO controls.
- The authors test for spillovers by comparing within-village controls with pure control villages.
- Limitations remain: mechanism evidence is not full structural mediation, and the study does not measure lifetime outcomes or equilibrium effects under universal rollout.

5 Tables and figures

5.1 Table I: Economic Activities by Terciles of Durable Assets

Read: Table I establishes baseline socioeconomic gradients by durable-asset tercile. The upper tercile has far more durable assets, tools, housing value, livestock, and cattle than the lower tercile. Human capital differences are also visible.

Economic message. The table motivates the aspirations story: poorer households live near better-off households but may not translate that exposure into higher investments without a resonant role-model narrative.

TABLE I
ECONOMIC ACTIVITIES BY TERCILES OF DURABLE ASSETS

	Whole sample	Lower tercile	Middle tercile	Upper tercile	p-value	Observations
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Assets						
Value of durable assets excluding tools (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	18.72	0.00	5.40	51.25	.00	1,119
Value of tools (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	24.32	16.28	17.60	38.18	.00	1,111
Value of house (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	371.53	228.67	323.08	531.02	.00	1,082
Total savings (US\$) PPP	10.25	6.95	11.08	12.14	.01	2,020
Has any savings	0.23	0.22	0.23	0.25	.15	2,048
Livestock						
Value of livestock (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	411.49	281.09	348.13	590.91	.00	1,110
Value of cattle (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	366.87	235.44	296.43	524.95	.00	1,118
Value of sheep or goat (US\$) per ad. equiv PPP	39.07	28.96	30.98	54.82	.00	1,118
Labor supply						
Household size	5.61	5.36	6.28	5.30	.72	1,119
Daily minutes in paid work per adult aged above 15	11.68	14.28	9.75	10.11	.20	1,109
Daily minutes on family farm per adult aged above 15	308.90	300.24	306.35	318.95	.08	1,110

(a) Assets, livestock, labor supply

TABLE I
CONTINUED

	Whole sample	Lower tercile	Middle tercile	Upper tercile	p-value	Observations
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Human capital investment						
Share of children at school in the 7–15 age group	0.58	0.57	0.57	0.61	.18	802
Schooling expenditure per child aged 7–15 (US\$) PPP	17.47	16.92	17.45	18.41	.53	1,110
Highest education level among male adults (years)	3.43	3.02	3.22	4.03	.00	1,045
Highest education level among female adults (years)	1.08	0.88	0.97	1.45	.00	1,025
Respondent's demographic characteristics						
Years of education	1.33	0.94	1.15	1.95	.00	2,048
Listens to radio at least once a week	0.61	0.50	0.49	0.83	.00	2,044
Ever lived outside of current district six months	0.10	0.08	0.10	0.11	.08	2,045
Father has any education	0.16	0.13	0.15	0.20	.00	2,048

Note: Column (1) is the sample mean. Columns (2)–(4) are sample means, conditional on the household being in the lower, middle, and upper terciles of the value of durable assets (excluding tools) at baseline, an approximation for living standards. Column (5) reports the p-value from a test of equality between the mean of the lower and upper tercile. Column (6) reports the number of observations. Variables are measured at the household level at baseline, except savings and demographic characteristics, which are measured for both the household head and spouse. The number of observations varies slightly across rows because some respondents do not answer all questions and because we trim continuous variables above the 99th percentile. Variables are defined in detail in [Online Appendix C](#). The OECD adult equivalence scale gives weight 0.5 to each individual younger than 18 and weight 0.7 to all other adults that are not the household head. Durable assets include radios, mobile phones, poultry, and furniture. Tools include ploughs, looms, and axes. The value of house is how much their house would cost to build today (in current prices), including materials and labor costs. Total savings refers to the value of savings held inside and outside the house. Livestock and durable assets are valued using self-reported hypothetical sale prices. All monetary values are in purchasing power parity (PPP)-adjusted US\$, set at 2018 (end line) prices and deflated using the national unified Consumer Price Index. In 2018, US\$1 = 8.67 ETH (Ethiopian birr) PPP. The conversion is described in [Online Appendix C.1](#).

(b) Education and demographics

5.2 Table II: Aspirations by Terciles of Durable Assets

Read: Average aspirations are high relative to current living standards, but richer households report higher aspirations and expectations. Aspired income rises from about \$18,012 PPP in the lower tercile to \$27,358 in the upper tercile, while expected income is lower than aspired income.

Economic message. The table shows an aspiration/expectation gradient with wealth, supporting the idea that perceived future possibilities differ across households.

5.3 Table III: Treatment Effects on Effort, Investment, and Productive Assets

Read: Treated respondents work about 28 additional minutes per day; treatment raises modern crop-input use and feed/veterinary-input use by about 10 percentage points; the agricultural investment index rises by 0.21 standard deviations relative to control.

Economic message. The table is the core evidence that the videos changed forward-looking production behavior.

5.4 Table IV: Treatment Effects on Educational Investments

Read: Treatment raises schooling time, study time, eighth-grade attainment, school expenditures, and the education investment index, especially for children who were 11–15 at the time of the intervention.

Economic message. The education results show that changed aspirations affect intergenerational investment.

5.5 Table V: Treatment Effects on Consumption, Durable Goods, and Well-Being

Read: Treatment reduces months of food insecurity, raises durable assets and housing value, and increases the welfare index; current consumption rises little.

Economic message. The table indicates that households continue to invest rather than simply consume more.

TABLE III
TREATMENT EFFECTS ON EFFORT, INVESTMENT, AND PRODUCTIVE ASSETS

	Treatment	Placebo	Treat. versus placebo	Control mean (Std. dev.) Total obs.
After five years	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Household head and spouse's labor effort				
Daily minutes working	28.01*** (7.80) [0.00]***	8.87 (7.97) [0.26]	19.14** (7.95) [0.03]**	326.16 (200.01) 1,754
Daily minutes in leisure	-48.62*** (9.98) [0.00]***	-30.06*** (10.41) [0.01]***	-18.55* (10.32) [0.07]*	830.59 (187.38) 1,773
Agricultural investment				
% with any spending on modern crop inputs	0.10*** (0.03) [0.01]**	0.04 (0.03) [0.58]	0.06* (0.03) [0.29]	0.58 (0.49) 1,089
Spending on seed or fertilizer (US\$) PPP	7.33** (3.07) [0.05]**	3.80 (3.32) [0.58]	3.53 (3.31) [0.38]	33.49 (43.54) 1,078
% with any spending on feed or vet supplies	0.10*** (0.03) [0.01]**	-0.04 (0.03) [0.58]	0.14*** (0.03) [0.00]***	0.45 (0.50) 1,089
Spending on feed or vet supplies (US\$) PPP	2.68 (4.81) [0.66]	-1.84 (4.81) [0.91]	4.52 (4.63) [0.38]	29.30 (70.92) 1081
% with any spending on hired crop labor	-0.05** (0.02) [0.05]**	-0.02 (0.02) [0.58]	-0.03 (0.02) [0.38]	0.36 (0.48) 1,089
Spending on hired crop labor (US\$) PPP	-1.30 (5.45) [0.81]	-4.97 (5.51) [0.59]	3.67 (5.42) [0.50]	54.16 (93.01) 1,078
Value of family crop labor (US\$) PPP	33.33* (19.73) [0.15]	1.27 (19.39) [0.95]	32.06 (20.08) [0.29]	387.81 (258.03) 1,079
Area cultivated (ha)	0.01 (0.02) [0.65]	-0.01 (0.02) [0.91]	0.02 (0.02) [0.38]	0.55 (0.30) 1,071
Assets				
Value of livestock (US\$) PPP	112.75 (122.97) [0.36]	23.24 (117.11) [0.84]	89.51 (114.28) [0.51]	2,018.22 (1,921.09) 1,053
Value of tools (USD) PPP	21.27** (10.77) [0.10]*	12.77 (12.30) [0.60]	8.50 (12.87) [0.51]	106.02 (126.90) 1,049
Summary index				
Agricultural investment index	0.21*** (0.06) [0.00]***	0.03 (0.06) [0.96]	0.18*** (0.06) [0.01]***	-0.00 (1.00) 1,082

TABLE II
ASPIRATIONS BY TERCILES OF DURABLE ASSETS

	Whole sample (1)	Lower tercile (2)	Middle tercile (3)	Upper tercile (4)	p-value (5)	Observations (6)
Aspirations: What you like to achieve?						
Aspired income (US\$) PPP		18,012.02	21,106.74	27,358.05	0.00	2,017
Aspired wealth (US\$) PPP		9,143.45	11,319.29	17,365.90	0.00	2,025
Aspired education (years)		13.90	13.88	14.39	0.00	2,000
Expectations: What do you think you will achieve?						
Expected income (US\$) PPP		6,079.67	4,507.98	4,695.10	5.96270	2,014
Expected wealth (US\$) PPP		3,981.22	3,501.22	6,084.35	0.00	2,011
Expected education (years)		13.49	13.30	13.28	13.86	2,026

Notes. Columns (1) to (5) are the sample mean. Columns (2) to (4) are sample means, reported on the household being in the lower, middle, and upper terciles of the value of durable assets (excluding tools) at baseline, as an approximation for living standards. Column (5) reports the value from a *t*-test of equality between the mean of the lower and upper terciles. Column (6) reports the number of observations. Variables are measured at baseline for both the household head and spouse. The number of observations varies slightly across rows because some respondents do not answer all questions and because we trim continuous variables above the 99th percentile. Variables are defined in detail in [Online Appendix C](#). To measure aspirations, respondents are asked the levels of activities they would like their household to achieve, on three dimensions. Annual income is the amount of cash income the household earns from all agricultural and nonagricultural activities in a year. Wealth is durable wealth (including housing, vehicles, furniture, and other valuable durable). Applied education level is the highest level of education attained by the respondent. Aspirations are measured at baseline and the response is the number of years the respondent expects to reach in 10 years. All monetary values are in PPP-adjusted US\$, set at 2016 (end line) prices and deflated using the national nonfood CPI. In 2016, US\$1 = 8.67 RBT (Ethiopian birr) PPP. The conversion is described in [Online Appendix C](#).

TABLE IV
TREATMENT EFFECTS ON EDUCATIONAL INVESTMENTS

	Treatment	Placebo	Treat. versus placebo	Control mean (Std. dev.)
After five years	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Cohort 1: Children of post-primary school-going age at end line (aged 11–15 at the time of the intervention)				
Children aged 16–20 in school	0.06* (0.03)	0.00	0.06 (0.03)	0.17 (0.41)
Daily minutes in school for children aged 16–20	0.08* (0.03)	0.94 (13.48)	0.94 (30.69)	1.078 (58.64)
Daily minutes studying for children aged 16–20	0.03** (0.00)	0.94 (13.48)	0.91 (30.71)	1.070 (149.88)
Daily minutes studying for children aged 16–20 that attained 8th grade	0.95** (0.08)	1.69 (4.81)	0.56 (5.05)	17.82 (52.12)
Children aged 16–20 that attained 8th grade	0.06* (0.03)	0.94 (0.02)	0.13 (0.03)	1.063 (0.26)
	0.00*** (0.00)	0.94 (0.02)	0.04 (0.03)	1.078 (0.26)
Cohort 2: Children of primary school-going age at end line (aged 2–10 at the time of the intervention)				
Children aged 7–15 in school	0.03 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.05 (0.03)	1.22 (1.18)
Daily minutes in school for children aged 7–15	0.67 (30.16)	0.82 (29.03)	0.52 (30.22)	1.078 (437.21)
Daily minutes studying for children aged 7–15	0.65 (17.34)	0.82 (9.78)	0.52 (7.56)	1.060 (91.29)
	0.03 (0.16)	0.56 (0.76)	0.54 (0.52)	1.115 (1.061)
For all children				
Schooling expenditure (US\$) PPP	6.97** (2.84)	1.17 (2.53)	5.81** (2.95)	19.17 (32.73)
	0.01*** (0.00)	0.64 (0.05)	0.05** (0.01)	1.065 (1.082)
Summary index	0.25** (0.07)	0.04 (0.07)	0.21** (0.08)	0.00 (1.00)
Educational investment index	0.00*** (0.00)	0.96 (0.01)	0.00*** (0.00)	1.082 (1.082)

TABLE V
TREATMENT EFFECTS ON CONSUMPTION, DURABLE GOODS, AND WELL-BEING

	Treatment	Placebo	Treat. versus placebo	Control mean (Std. dev.) Total obs.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
After five years				
Food security	-0.07	-0.10	0.03	0.48
Food security index z-score	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.92)
	(0.28)	(0.22)	(0.61)	0.76
Months of food insecurity	-0.33**	0.40	-0.38***	2.71
	(0.15)	(0.15)	(0.14)	(2.13)
	(0.05)**		(0.02)**	1.038
Consumption				
Food consumption (US\$ per ad. equiv. monthly PPP)	-1.98	-2.29	0.32	53.91
	(2.05)	(1.92)	(2.07)	(29.88)
	(0.38)	(0.38)	(0.88)	1.076
Frequent non-food (1m recall US\$ per ad. equiv. PPP)	0.44	0.04	0.40	0.48
	(0.28)	(0.28)	(0.30)	(3.69)
Nonfood consumption (12m recall US\$ per ad. equiv. monthly PPP)	0.19	0.94	[0.25]	1.076
	(0.13)	(0.13)	(0.14)	(1.66)
	(0.51)	(0.43)	(0.48)	(6.35)
	(0.21)	(0.58)	(0.05)*	1.079
Consumption of sin goods (US\$ PPP)	0.20	0.04	0.17	0.80
	(0.13)	(0.12)	(0.13)	(1.66)
	(0.19)	(0.94)	(0.25)	1.078
General economic position (scale 1-4)	0.09*	0.00	0.09*	2.10
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.73)
	(0.19)	(0.94)	(0.21)	1.085
Nonproductive durables and housing				
Value of durable assets excluding tools (US\$) PPP	20.71**	-1.65	22.36**	70.55
	(9.97)	(6.77)	(10.17)	(127.39)
	(0.08)	(0.85)	(0.08)	1.042
Value of house (US\$) PPP	384.94**	83.72	301.22**	1,184.27
	(90.70)	(81.93)	(90.18)	(1,235.57)
	(0.00)***	(0.43)	(0.00)***	1.020
Nonagricultural roof	0.01	0.03	-0.01	0.68
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.47)
	(0.59)	(0.43)	(0.64)	1.036
Own toilet facility	0.07*	0.04	0.04	0.28
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.49)
	(0.44)	(0.43)	(0.64)	1.039

TABLE V
CONTINUED

CONTINUED				
	Treatment	Placebo	Treat. vers. placebo	Control mean (Std. dev.) Total obs.
After five years	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Well-being				
Best life	0.22** (0.09)	0.10 (0.11)	0.12 (0.11)	4.83 1.801
Happiest life	0.12 (0.14)	0.12 (0.10)	0.00 (0.14)	6.95 (2.19)
Summary index	0.38 (0.08)	0.40 (0.04)	0.98 (0.08)	1.885
Welfare index	0.15** (0.07)	0.01 (0.07)	0.14** (0.04)	-0.00 (1.00)
	[0.03]**	[0.96]	[0.04]**	1090

[illegible]

5.9 Table VII: Treatment Effects on Summary Indices

Read: Agricultural investment rises by 0.21 standard deviations, education by 0.25, welfare by 0.15, aspirations by 0.12, expectations by 0.21, and the omnibus index by 0.26 relative to control.

Economic message. This table summarizes the paper: persistent effects appear across investment, welfare, and beliefs, while placebo effects are close to zero.

TABLE VII
TREATMENT EFFECTS ON SUMMARY INDICES

	Treatment	Placebo	Treat. versus placebo	Control mean (Std. dev.) Total obs.
After five years	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Agricultural investment index	0.21*** (0.06) [0.00]***	0.03 (0.06) [0.96]	0.18*** (0.06) [0.00]***	−0.00 (1.00) 1,082
Educational investment index	0.25*** (0.07) [0.00]***	0.04 (0.07) [0.96]	0.21*** (0.08) [0.00]***	0.00 (1.00) 1,082
Welfare index	0.15** (0.07) [0.03]**	0.01 (0.07) [0.96]	0.14** (0.07) [0.04]**	−0.00 (1.00) 1,090
Aspiration index	0.12** (0.05) [0.02]**	−0.03 (0.05) [0.96]	0.15*** (0.05) [0.00]***	0.02 (1.00) 1,904
Expectations index	0.21*** (0.05) [0.00]***	−0.00 (0.05) [0.96]	0.22*** (0.05) [0.00]***	0.01 (1.00) 1,900
Aspirations and expectations aggregate index	0.19*** (0.05) [0.00]***	−0.03 (0.05) [0.96]	0.22*** (0.05) [0.00]***	0.01 (1.00) 1,904
Omnibus index	0.26*** (0.06) [0.00]***	0.02 (0.06) [0.96]	0.24*** (0.07) [0.00]***	−0.00 (1.00) 1,091

Notes. OLS estimates of within-village treatment and placebo effects five years after the intervention (columns (1) and (2)). Column (3) tests for differences in parameters obtained in the first two columns. The comparison group comprises households from the 64 treated villages that were not invited to any screening. Column (4) displays the control mean, standard deviation, and total number of observations. All columns control for village fixed effects and characteristics of the household head (or spouse for individual-level outcomes): age, years of education, an indicator for being single, and an indicator for being male. Regressions control for the baseline value of the outcome, except for the regressions on the agricultural investment index, welfare index, and omnibus index, which control for the respective index constructed from all the available components available at baseline. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors (or clustered at the household level for individual-level outcomes) are in parentheses. Asterisks on the coefficient estimates reflect unadjusted p -values. Minimum p -values are in square brackets and are calculated over each panel of variables. The unit of observation is the household, except for the aspirations and expectations indices (which are observed for both household head and their spouse). The number of observations varies slightly across rows because some respondents do not answer all questions and because we trim continuous outcomes above the 99th percentile, though the indices aggregate all non-missing outcomes. The outcomes are inverse-covariance-weighted averages standardized relative to the within-village control group, following Anderson (2008). The agricultural-investment index includes all outcomes reported in Table III, with household's daily minutes in leisure being recoded to be negative. The educational-investment index includes all outcomes reported in Table IV. The welfare index includes all outcomes reported in Table V, with months of food insecurity in the last year recoded to be negative. The welfare index averages over the household head's subjective well-being outcomes. The aspirations and expectations indices are made of the reported aspirations (expectations) for income, wealth, and years of education for children. The omnibus index aggregates the agricultural-investment, educational-investment, welfare, and aspirations and expectations aggregate standardized indices into a single index, following Kling, Liebman, and Katz (2007). We use the household head's aspirations and expectations aggregate index for the omnibus index. * $p < .10$, ** $p < .05$, *** $p < .01$.

Figure 2: Table VII: summary indices and omnibus index

6 Short summary

- A one-hour documentary intervention changed long-run behavior in rural Ethiopia.
- Treated households worked more, invested more in agricultural inputs, accumulated more tools and durables, and increased education investments.
- Aspirations and expectations increased after five years.
- Alternative mechanisms such as preferences, grit, information, and fertilizer-return beliefs are not supported as the main explanation.
- The omnibus index effect is 0.26 standard deviations relative to control and 0.24 relative to placebo.

7 Conclusion

7.1 Core conclusion

A one-hour exposure to documentary role models generated persistent changes in investment and welfare over a five-year horizon. The intervention is light-touch and provides no assets, credit, training, or mentoring.

7.2 Mechanism and interpretation

The most compelling mechanism is aspirations: treatment raises desired goals and expected future outcomes, while alternative channels show little persistent movement.

7.3 Implications for poverty traps

The results support models where beliefs and goals shape economic choices, making poverty partly self-reinforcing through low aspirations.

7.4 Policy implications

Role-model content may be a scalable complement to traditional development programs when households have feasible investment opportunities but underinvest because success feels unattainable.

7.5 Limitations and open questions

The study does not measure lifetime outcomes or equilibrium effects under universal rollout. The mechanism evidence is strong but not a full structural mediation analysis.

7.6 Takeaway

Aspirations are not just survey attitudes. In this experiment, they are linked to measurable changes in labor supply, investment, education, assets, and welfare.